

## IN PROFILE

### Mily Balakirev

Balakirev was only two years older than Mussorgsky, but his influence was crucial. He was the leader of the Mighty Handful (who were also known as The Five), the driving force behind new Russian music. Balakirev agreed to give Mussorgsky lessons and, for a while at least, this arrangement ran smoothly. At his peak, Balakirev was a fine composer—best known for *Islamey*, a showpiece for the piano, based on a Caucasian dance—but his circumstances were as testing as those of his pupil. He had a reclusive and quarrelsome nature, which alienated many of his friends. He also suffered a mental breakdown, which cost him his job as a railroad clerk.

Modest Mussorgsky was born into a world of privilege. His father was a wealthy landowner with aristocratic roots that could be traced back to the 9th century. Unfortunately for his heirs, this wealth was dependent on the unpaid labor of the many serfs who ran his estates. When Alexander II freed the serfs in 1861, the family's fortunes were fatally undermined.

By this stage, Mussorgsky was launched on his haphazard musical career. Details of his childhood are sketchy, but he was born on the country estate in the Pskov district, about 250 miles (400 km) south of St. Petersburg, and showed great musical promise, having taken piano lessons with his mother. But after studying at a military academy, he enrolled in the Preobrazhensky regiment, and then seemed destined for an army career.